WAVERLEY GATEWAY GUIDE

Connecting International Capital with Emerging & Frontier Markets

KAZAKHSTAN

Eurasia

Information current as of October 2026

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WHERE AND HOW TO ENTER

KEY INVESTMENT LOCATIONS

Location / Region	Strategic Importance	Priority Sectors
Astana	Capital; seat of government and a growing financial and administrative hub	Financial services, administration, construction
Almaty	Largest city and commercial capital; leading centre for banking, IT and trade, and gateway to Alatau City, a new special legal regime for technology and digital assets	Financial services, IT, retail, real estate
Atyrau / Tengiz (west)	Core oil-production region; Tengiz field and Caspian coast oil infrastructure	Oil and gas, oilfield services
Aktau / Caspian Sea coast	Westernmost Caspian port; gateway for trans-Caspian trade on the Middle Corridor and a key channel for diversifying export routes	Port logistics, trans-Caspian trade, oil transshipment
Shymkent	Southern industrial hub with a major refinery that has added flexibility by processing additional domestic crude	Refining, manufacturing, agro-processing
Special Economic Zones (18 nationwide) and industrial zones (67)	Dedicated zones hosting 586 active investment projects with tax and customs incentives	Manufacturing, logistics, light industry
Atasu-Alashankou corridor (east, China border)	Pipeline and rail corridor carrying growing crude and trade volumes to China, with pipeline capacity expanding toward 146.6 million barrels a year	Energy transit, cross-border trade and logistics

INVESTOR ENTRY ROUTES

- Kazakh Invest (national investment promotion agency) provides one-stop facilitation, incentives, and sector guidance for foreign investors
- Investment agreements under the Investment Policy Concept through 2030 offering legislative stability guarantees for up to 25 years
- Astana International Financial Centre (AIFC), operating under English common law with its own independent court, offering a distinct regulatory environment for financial-services and related investment
- Special Economic Zones (18) and industrial zones (67) offering tax holidays and customs exemptions for qualifying manufacturing and export projects
- National Bank of Kazakhstan oversight of currency and capital-account activity; the tenge is free-floating with no major repatriation restrictions

- Production-sharing and joint-venture arrangements with KazMunayGas for oil and gas sector participation
- Altyn Visa programme offering tax advantages and streamlined residence procedures for international investors and entrepreneurs, alongside a National Digital Investment Platform acting as a one-stop shop

MARKET-ENTRY OBSERVATION

Kazakhstan in October 2026 combines strong and broadening economic fundamentals with a proven capacity to absorb external shocks. The non-oil economy continues to grow robustly: GDP expanded 4.1% in the first seven months of 2026 following 6.5% growth in 2025, with construction (+15.3%), manufacturing (+9%) and trade (+5.9%) leading real-sector growth even as oil output declined. Foreign direct investment reached $20.5 billion in 2025, up 14.4% year-on-year, with greenfield investment surging 266% to $19 billion and capturing nearly 89% of all Central Asian greenfield flows. The government's Investment Policy Concept through 2030, offering legislative stability guarantees for up to 25 years, an expanding network of special economic and industrial zones, and a new Constitution with investor-rights protections in force since July 2026 have materially improved the investment climate.

Kazakhstan's resilience has also been demonstrated in the energy sector. The Caspian Pipeline Consortium (CPC), which carries around 80% of Kazakhstan's crude exports and roughly 1% of global oil supply, has experienced periodic disruption from Black Sea conflict spillover since November 2025, including a temporary suspension of loadings in late July 2026. Operations were restored quickly on each occasion — loadings resumed on 27 July after about a week — and Tengiz production recovered after earlier interruptions. Kazakhstan has responded with measured diplomacy and practical action: engaging the US and EU on shipping security, directing additional crude to the Shymkent refinery, and accelerating diversification through the Atasu–Alashankou pipeline to China, whose capacity is set to reach 146.6 million barrels a year, and through increased trans-Caspian shipments. The wider economy has strengthened at the same time, with a $2.4 billion current account surplus in H1 2026 and combined reserves and National Fund assets of almost $139 billion providing a substantial buffer.

INVESTOR RISK & MARKET ACCESS

KEY ENTRY BARRIERS

Issue	Potential Impact	Possible Mitigation
CPC export route and Black Sea security	Periodic attacks on CPC infrastructure since November 2025 have caused temporary export suspensions; operations have been restored on each occasion, most recently within about a week in July 2026	Strong reserve buffers and an active diversification programme cushion the economy; investors with oil-revenue exposure can build short-disruption scenarios into planning
Concentration of oil exports on one main route	The CPC remains the principal oil-export channel, carrying around 80% of crude exports, while alternative routes are being scaled up	Expansion of China-bound and trans-Caspian routes is steadily reducing concentration and creating investment opportunities in pipelines, ports and storage
Landlocked geography	Distance from open seas adds to trade costs, but Kazakhstan has turned its position into a transit advantage, carrying around 85% of China–Europe rail freight	Position investments to benefit from Middle Corridor transit growth and ongoing rail, road and Smart Cargo digital-customs upgrades
Governance and rule of law	Reform momentum is strong — a new Constitution with investor-rights protections, a Prosecutorial Filter on inspections of investors and an Investment Board resolving investor issues — with progress on international governance indices ongoing	Use AIFC structures (English common law, independent court and arbitration centre) and the Investment Board's fast-track support
Currency movements linked to oil revenues	The tenge can respond to oil-market and regional developments, but is supported by a current account surplus, gross reserves of $70.6 billion and the National Fund	Apply standard hedging for projects with significant local-currency exposure; easing interest rates are improving local financing conditions
Regional spillover from the Russia–Ukraine war	Kazakhstan maintains a neutral, multi-vector foreign policy with open channels	Kazakhstan's balanced diplomacy and deepening ties with the EU, US, China and

Issue	Potential Impact	Possible Mitigation
	to all major partners, although conflict-linked incidents have affected some export infrastructure	Gulf partners support stability; monitor developments as part of routine logistics planning
Scaling of alternative export routes	China-bound pipeline capacity is expanding toward 146.6 million barrels a year — around 28% of CPC capacity — with trans-Caspian volumes also growing	Treat diversification as a multi-year growth story offering opportunities in pipeline, port and logistics infrastructure

INVESTOR RISK NOTE

Kazakhstan's risk profile reflects a country with increasingly credible non-oil fundamentals, strong financial buffers and a track record of managing external shocks. The government's investment-climate reforms, legislative stability guarantees of up to 25 years, the new Constitution's investor-rights provisions and the AIFC's common-law framework are genuine and sustained improvements that have driven strong foreign direct investment, including nearly 89% of Central Asia's greenfield flows in 2025. The CPC disruptions of late 2025 and 2026 were external in origin, and the speed with which exports were restored, together with a return to current account surplus in H1 2026, demonstrates the economy's resilience. Kazakhstan's balanced diplomacy and accelerating diversification toward China and the trans-Caspian route are steadily reducing concentration risk. Investors in oil-linked sectors should include short-term disruption scenarios in their planning, while investors across the wider economy can take comfort from the depth of Kazakhstan's reserves and the breadth of its non-oil growth.

MARKET ACCESS

Kazakhstan is a member of the Eurasian Economic Union (EAEU), providing tariff-free access to Russia, Belarus, Armenia and Kyrgyzstan — a market of more than 180 million people — and is a central link in the Trans-Caspian International Transport Route (Middle Corridor), which complements China's Belt and Road Initiative and has grown in strategic importance since 2022. The country has been a WTO member since 2015 and has an Enhanced Partnership and Cooperation Agreement with the EU, which takes around 60% of Kazakhstan's crude oil and petroleum product exports. Oil exports flow mainly via the CPC pipeline to Novorossiysk, with growing volumes moving to China via the Atasu–Alashankou pipeline and westward across the Caspian. This combination of EAEU membership, Western partnerships and Chinese connectivity gives Kazakhstan a genuinely multi-directional market access profile, with export flexibility increasing as new routes are scaled up.

WHO SHOULD THE INVESTOR MEET?

INSTITUTIONAL LANDSCAPE

Actor	Why It Matters	Waverley Engagement Angle
Office of the President (Kassym-Jomart Tokayev)	Sets overarching economic reform and energy-diversification policy, including export-route diversification	Primary reference point for understanding Kazakhstan's strategic direction
Kazakh Invest	National investment promotion agency; principal facilitation body for foreign investors	Standard first point of contact for market entry and incentive guidance
Astana International Financial Centre (AIFC)	Independent, English-common-law-based financial and commercial jurisdiction with its own court system	Preferred structuring venue for financial-services and cross-border transactions
KazMunayGas (national oil and gas company)	Dominant state energy company and central counterpart for oil and gas sector investment and CPC-related matters	Essential partner for any energy-sector engagement
National Bank of Kazakhstan	Monetary authority; manages the free-floating tenge	Relevant for currency and banking-sector matters
Caspian Pipeline Consortium (CPC)	International consortium (including major global oil companies) operating the critical Novorossiysk export pipeline	Key counterpart for any oil-sector or export-logistics investment
Ministry of Foreign Affairs	Leads Kazakhstan's balanced, multi-	Relevant for understanding Kazakhstan's

Actor	Why It Matters	Waverley Engagement Angle
	vector diplomacy with Russia, China, the EU, the US and regional partners	geopolitical positioning and partnership opportunities

CURRENT INTERNATIONAL BUSINESS CHANNELS

The American Chamber of Commerce in Kazakhstan and the EU-Kazakhstan Business Council are the leading Western business associations, alongside the National Chamber of Entrepreneurs "Atameken" for domestic business liaison. Kazakh Invest runs regular investor forums and maintains active sector-specific outreach. Major international oil companies with Tengiz and CPC stakes maintain substantial in-country presence and are a useful source of practical intelligence on energy-export logistics. The World Bank, EBRD, and Asian Development Bank maintain active country programs supporting infrastructure, energy transition, and private-sector development, and the AIFC itself increasingly functions as a networking and dealmaking hub for regional financial-services investment.

INVESTOR PROFILE BEST SUITED

Kazakhstan suits a broad range of investors seeking exposure to a growing, diversifying economy with strong financial buffers: manufacturing and logistics investors benefiting from the Special Economic Zone incentive framework and Middle Corridor positioning; financial-services and fintech investors leveraging the AIFC's common-law structure; technology investors drawn by the national AI and digital agenda; and agriculture and food-processing investors building on strong recent growth in that sector. Oil and gas investors benefit from world-class resources and long-standing international partnerships, and should build standard contingency planning for export-route disruption into project economics.

FROM INTELLIGENCE TO ENGAGEMENT

STEP 1: Engage Kazakh Invest and assess current incentive terms
Open direct dialogue with the national investment promotion agency to understand sector-specific incentives under the Investment Policy Concept through 2030.

STEP 2: Evaluate AIFC structuring for financial and cross-border transactions
Consider the Astana International Financial Centre's common-law framework for transactions benefiting from greater legal predictability.

STEP 3: Build export-route scenarios into oil-sector and export-linked planning
Model short-term disruption scenarios, informed by the 2026 precedents in which CPC operations were restored quickly, for any investment with oil-revenue sensitivity.

STEP 4: Track diversification-route expansion
Follow China-corridor and trans-Caspian capacity growth, which is both reducing CPC concentration and creating new logistics investment opportunities.

STEP 5: Leverage Special Economic Zone incentives for manufacturing and logistics entry
Engage the relevant zone authorities directly to secure tax and customs incentives for qualifying export-oriented projects.